

tracked clear across the northwestern New Mexico area and was projected to fly over the North Range from the West and straight into Texas. All camera crews and photographers were to report to the motor pool with their equipment. They were told no more than that. Some were still drunk from celebrating. Some were in civilian clothes, the MPs were picking them up everywhere.

Q. What happened next?

A. The convoy left the base and proceeded North up the highway and then turned West into the range, Paul told me. It took about an hour to get to where we were supposed to go. Crossed a lot of open sand until we reached some hilly area. After they stopped, they fanned out in a long line and started to move toward the hilly area. Most had flashlights and some vehicles had searchlights. The Askania camera operators were told to point their cameras towards the northwest. We all thought it was the balloons launched the previous day. They had brought some 80's and starshell (illumination) rounds. Why? For balloons! Some time around midnight, the tube crews dropped some illumination rounds -- lots of them. They lit up the whole sky pretty good, Paul said. A radioman yelled for the colonel to come to the radio van. Then, he yelled out for all cameras to train at a certain heading their cameras at a certain angle (relative to true North and compass bearing). Sometime around midnight, the mortar crews started to drop illumination rounds again. A bright object was approaching from the northwest at a 60 degree position in the night sky (from the horizon). All Askania cameras were tracking the object until it disappeared behind some hills.

Q. What happened then?

A. My 1st Sergeant buddy said that the search teams got back in their vehicles and drove off in the direction where the craft came down. It took another hour before they reached the landing site. Some MPs found a large metallic disc resting against a sand hill, slightly tilted. It was approximately 100 to 150 ft. or so in diameter, maybe larger. Difficult to tell for sure because it was dark and only the reflection of the searchlights was visible from my position (approx. 100 yards away). There were a lot of lights being shone on the craft and a lot of base personnel surrounding the craft but keeping a respectable distance from it. Everyone was excited and scared at the same time. They soon brought generators and floodlights for better lighting.

Q. What did the 1st Sergeant see at the landing site?

A. He did not see much. He was some distance away. He could see a big disc-like craft with a flat bottom and a slightly round shaped dome on top. It was shiny with a rim surrounding the craft. It was big, kinda grayish in color but very shiny -- a lot of MPs and base technicians surrounding it. They seemed to just stand there looking at it. All the time they were taking pictures with flashbulbs and there were some motion picture photographers taking pictures as well. A little later (about 2 or 3 AM in the morning) some of the technicians were able to climb on top of the craft. Some had black rubber suits on with geiger counters, I think, (checking for radiation possibly). About 3 AM in the morning, some scientists and engineers had arrived. They began to put up canvas all around the craft and set up a command post and storage tents. There were a lot of guards surrounding the site. He knew that some of the scientists did not come from Alamogordo or White Sands because they were accompanied by some high ranking generals. They appeared to enter a tent and emerged wearing some overalls and carrying masks of some kind. There were trucks arriving and departing all morning. I think I heard aircraft flying or landing nearby near the highway. I do not know what these trucks were transporting, but it must have been important. By 6 or 7 AM that morning, the Askania crews were ordered out of the area and back to Alamogordo. There were security checkpoints all along the way to the highway. All of us were debriefed at Alamogordo by CIC people and had to sign non-disclosure statements as to what we did, saw, and heard. That was when I saw him first. He told me some days afterward.

Q. When did you become involved with this event?

A. As I told you before, I was in my office a few days after I saw Paul. It was at the Base Production Unit. We were printing the results of a V-2 launch when the base commander, Colonel Helmek, arrived at the building with a detail of MPs that surrounded the premises and ordered everybody to leave except me. The rest, you already know.